

Libya



Situated on north Africa's Mediterranean coast, Libya was declared a revolutionary state in 1969 by Colonel Gaddafi, who promotes Islam, African unity, and a communal lifestyle.



GEOGRAPHY

Apart from the coastal strip and a mountain range in the south, Libya is desert or semidesert. Natural oases provide the agricultural land.



CLIMATE

Hot and arid. The coastal area has a temperate climate, with mild, wet winters and hot, dry summers.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Libyans are of Arab and Berber origin. Once a nation of nomads and livestock herders, it is almost 80% urban. Revolution wiped out private enterprise and the middle classes. Jews and European settlers were banished. Years of political marginalization and sanctions ended after Libya offered compensation for terrorist bombings. The voluntary ending of its Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMD) program was also welcomed by the West.

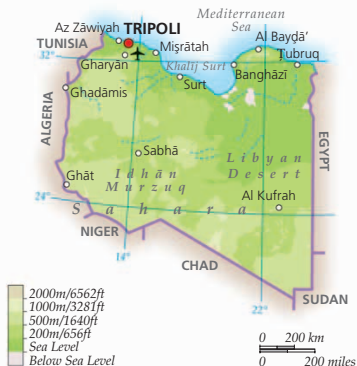


THE ECONOMY

Oil is key export. Dates, olives, and fruit grow in oases, but most food is imported. Corruption and mismanagement. High inflation.



INSIGHT: 90% of Libya is still desert, despite grand irrigation projects



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Great Socialist People's Libyan Arab Jamahariyah

DATE OF FORMATION: 1951

CAPITAL: Tripoli

POPULATION: 6.42 million

TOTAL AREA: 679,358 sq. miles
(1,759,540 sq. km)

DENSITY: 9 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, Tuareg

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 97%,
other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab and Berber 95%,
other 5%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: Libyan dinar = 1000 dirhams